“Wartime” vs “Peacetime” at Tech Companies

The difference between the two operating modes at tech companies, and how to thrive in each of these environments.

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I asked several startup founders about trends they’re observing in their businesses, and at other new companies. Several mentioned there’s an accelerating shift to a “wartime” mindset. This phrase is becoming more common at larger companies, as well.

So what is “wartime?” How does it compare and contrast to those periods we can call “peacetime?” How do these different states affect employees, and how can you thrive in them? In today’s article, we aim to help answer this question, covering:

1. **From wartime to peacetime at Uber.** My observations from the shift.
2. **Wartime vs peacetime in tech.** What is “wartime” and “peacetime,” and more generally, what is it with using military phrases in a tech context?
3. **Differences between wartime and peacetime**. The contrasts.
4. **Where does crunchtime fit in?** And why is it more likely to indicate crunchtime?
5. **Transitioning between wartime and peacetime.** And signs that make it clear when such a transition happens.
6. **Thriving in wartime vs thriving in peacetime**. Approaches that work better in the different stages.
7. **Tech debt during wartime and peacetime.** Why do companies in lengthy wartime phases not suffer badly with “tech debt?” A few interesting explanations.

In this article I use the term "wartime" strictly in the business sense. Hard times at a company are in no way comparable to real warfare and the suffering it causes to innocent victims and affected communities. At present, the largest war in Europe since World War 2 is ongoing; the Russian invasion of Ukraine. I reflect on this tragedy in an article published shortly after it started.

1. From wartime to peacetime at Uber

When I joined Uber in 2016 the company was doing well – at least that's how it seemed from the outside – after raising $5.6B at a $66B valuation a few months before. Once inside, I found things were fast-paced and hectic; it felt like many projects were "life or death" matters.

My first project was like this: the rewrite of Uber's mobile app. Most engineering teams began on it in June 2016, with a deadline of 16 September 2016 to complete a full rewrite for the app and all existing functionality, to a new codebase. On Android, we kept using Java, but moved over to a new architecture called RIBs. On iOS, it involved switching languages from Objective C to Swift, as well as using the new RIBs architecture.

Looking back, this project was the single craziest march I've been part of. I share my experience in a separate article. I traveled to San Francisco and was able to work crazy hours, without family commitments. It was crunchtime at its best – or worst! – with 80+ hour weeks, 7 days a week, often working past midnight.

Around the same time, Ariana Huffington joined Uber's board, after her book on the importance of sleep came out. That message was visibly at odds with the reality of working at HQ past midnight and missing out on sleep.

At first I thought Uber's Rider app rewrite was a one-off crunchtime event. However, it wasn't: other projects felt equally high pressure and we operated on the understanding that we needed to move fast, or else... Or else, what? Looking back, most deadlines were artificial; set by the CEO without any external reason to hit it. Still, we never questioned them and all marched to the leadership's tune.

Large parts of Uber operated like it was wartime for lengthy periods. This wasn't a vague feeling, we had terms for it: teams often called for a "War room" to get important projects done, or declared a "code red" or "code yellow" for critical initiatives. Conflicts between teams were not uncommon, as all were focused on moving fast and launching their features.

At the San Francisco HQ, one large meeting room was even named the "War Room." Unsurprisingly, this was where key people gathered to solve pressing problems.

Uber's transition to peacetime was very visible. In late 2017, Dara Khosrowshahi became CEO and the frantic pace rapidly cooled. As first steps, he announced company-wide priorities at the start of 2018 and we ran a more detailed planning cycle. There was a new sense of stability in the air which I'd not experienced before there.

Over the following year, Uber transitioned into peacetime. Much of this was surely deliberate by Dara, who arrived with the mandate to take Uber public. In 2017, Uber's reputation was turning negative and a priority was to stabilize the company and reassure current and future investors, in order to float successfully. For this, the business needed to calm down and operate more "maturely."

Engineering leadership made changes like adding "citizenship" as a sixth competency to the engineering career ladder, to recognize and encourage people going above and beyond to improve Uber as a workplace. The company invested significantly in diversity and inclusion; training, HR support for managers, hiring its first chief and diversity officer, and more. In a highly symbolic move, Dara renamed the "War Room" as the "Peace Room", signaling times had changed.

And this was very clear. Behaviors which were rewarded at "wartime Uber" were not necessarily helpful for advancing one's career at "peacetime Uber". For example, the values of "principled confrontation" and "meritocracy and toe-stepping" encouraged conflict if and when they helped choose the best approaches. However, when performance calibrations and promotions came around at the end of 2018, I noticed people who engaged in these behaviors got negative feedback for the first time.

2. Wartime and peacetime in tech

So what is "wartime" and "peacetime," and more generally, what is it with using military phrases in a tech context?

A case of this in tech was in the early 2010s, when Ben Horowitz – cofounder of VC firm Andreessen Horowitz published the article, "Peacetime CEO/Wartime CEO," writing:

> "Recently, Eric Schmidt stepped down as CEO of Google and founder Larry Page took over. Much of the news coverage focused on Page's ability to be the "face of Google" as Page is far more shy and introverted than the gregarious and articulate Schmidt. While an interesting issue, this analysis misses the main point. Eric Schmidt was much more than Google's front man; as Google's peacetime Chief Executive, he led the greatest technology business expansion in the last ten years. Larry Page, in contrast, seems to have determined that Google is moving into war and he clearly intends to be a wartime CEO. This will be a profound change for Google and the entire high-tech industry."

Here's how he defined peacetime and wartime:

> "Peacetime in business means those times when a company has a large advantage vs. the competition in its core market, and its market is growing. In times of peace, the company can focus on expanding the market and reinforcing the company's strengths.
>
> In wartime, a company is fending off an imminent existential threat. Such a threat can come from a wide range of sources including competition, dramatic macro-economic change, market change, supply chain change, and so forth. The great wartime CEO Andy Grove marvelously describes the forces that can take a company from peacetime to wartime in his book, Only The Paranoid Survive."

In the same article, Ben gave several examples of the differences in leadership styles, writing:

> "Peacetime CEO knows that proper protocol leads to winning. Wartime CEO violates protocol in order to win.

> Peacetime CEO focuses on the big picture and empowers her people to make detailed decisions. Wartime CEO cares about a speck of dust on a gnat's ass if it interferes with the prime directive.
>
> Peacetime CEO builds scalable, high-volume recruiting machines.
>
> Wartime CEO does that, but also builds HR organizations that can execute layoffs.
>
> Peacetime CEO spends time defining the culture. Wartime CEO lets the war define the culture.
>
> Peacetime CEO always has a contingency plan. Wartime CEO knows that sometimes you gotta roll a hard six [referring to the game of craps, where rolling a hard six means rolling 3 on each dice, which is a 3% chance of happening.]
>
> Peacetime CEO knows what to do with a big advantage. Wartime CEO is paranoid.
>
> Peacetime CEO strives not to use profanity. Wartime CEO sometimes uses profanity purposefully.
>
> Peacetime CEO thinks of the competition as other ships in a big ocean that may never engage. Wartime CEO thinks the competition is sneaking into her house and trying to kidnap her children.
>
> Peacetime CEO aims to expand the market. Wartime CEO aims to win the market.
>
> Peacetime CEO strives to tolerate deviations from the plan when coupled with effort and creativity. Wartime CEO is completely intolerant.
>
> Peacetime CEO does not raise her voice. Wartime CEO rarely speaks in a normal tone.
>
> Peacetime CEO works to minimize conflict. Wartime CEO heightens the contradictions.
>
> Peacetime CEO strives for broad-based buy-in. Wartime CEO neither indulges consensus building nor tolerates disagreements.

> Peacetime CEO sets big, hairy, audacious goals. Wartime CEO is too busy fighting the enemy to read management books written by consultants who have never managed a fruit stand.
>
> Peacetime CEO trains her employees to ensure satisfaction and career development. Wartime CEO trains her employees so they don't get their asses shot off in the battle.
>
> Peacetime CEO has rules like 'We're going to exit all businesses where we're not number 1 or 2 [in market position.'] Wartime CEO often has no businesses that are number one or two and therefore does not have the luxury of following that rule."

Even now, I find myself agreeing with many of these observations, recollecting the differences in how Travis Kalanick and his successor Dara Khosrowshahi operated at Uber.

The term "wartime" and "peacetime" stuck and became popular within tech. Why has such military language grown roots in the tech sector? I have no clear explanation, but it's interesting how stress-based language is dominant across tech, with terms like:

- "Deadline" – originating from the US Civil War
- "Pager alert" – from emergency services
- "All hands on deck" – a naval term
- "All hands" from the navy's "all hands" – assembling a ship's officers and captain
- "Postmortem" – a medical term
- "Breaking change" – similar to "breaking news" from the Press

Phrases like these are easily-understood concepts in a competitive business environment.

3. Differences between wartime and peacetime

How do these states differ from each other? Based on my observations and experience, there's a few major contrasts:

Area	Wartime	Peacetime
Business environment	Existential pressure	Little to no pressure
Focus on competition	Obsessed with rivals out-competing or threatening the business	No need to be obsessed with competition
#1 priority for dev teams	Shipping quickly	Shipping thoroughly validated features is the priority
Deadlines	Meeting deadlines is a must	Meeting deadlines is a bonus
Meetings	Reduce meetings in favor of getting things done. "Done is better than perfect"	It's normal to have lots of meetings to make sure everyone is aligned. "Alignment is more important than speed"
Conflict	Conflicts are okay if they help get things done	Conflict is not okay and isn't how things get done
Process	Break the process if it helps get stuff done	Follow the process; it exists for a reason
"Nice to have"	No focus on "nice to have" work	Lots of focus on "nice to have" work
Workplace frustration	It's normal to be overwhelmed and to let your emotions like stress and frustration. Rarely any repercussions for doing so.	This isn't okay if it involves behaving unprofessionally. Potential repercussions.
Work-life balance (WLB)	Work-life-what?	A considerable focus, and common to have WLB-friendly policies.

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Common differences between companies in wartime and peacetime modes. View this table as a document.

How do leadership styles tend to differ between each state? My observations:

Area	Wartime leadership	Peacetime leadership
Decision-making	Very decisive	Aims to find common ground
Prioritization	Ruthless in prioritizing getting the most important stuff done	Multiple promising work streams supported
Conflicts	Tackled head-on	Avoided
Imposing stress on employees	Common to "light a fire under people's asses"	Avoids stressing employees
Unpopular decisions	Frequent: leaders do what they see as necessary to meet priorities	Avoided: little to no need to make any group unhappy, especially not employees
Visibility of leadership	Visible and involved even in the fine detail	Less visible and not involved in most detail
Style	Raw, sometimes to the point of appearing unprofessional	Measured and professional

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Typical leadership behaviors in wartime vs in peacetime. View this table as a document

4. Where does crunchtime fit in?

Crunchtime refers to a timeboxed period when most members of a team do extra hours to get an important project done. This usually means working overtime and involves freeing up time by canceling meetings, non-essential work, and projects. What's true of any crunchtime is that it's stressful, but ends as soon as the project completes.

It's valid to ask if crunchtime is separate from "wartime" or "peacetime." After all, a company may be in peacetime mode but some projects may still involve some crunch, such as when meeting an immovable external deadline. But I don't really agree: I see it present with wartime much more.

Crunchtime is typical for organizations in wartime mode, but is rare during peacetime. This is because during peacetime, there's no big pressure and proper processes are followed for planning and tracking progress. This means that if a team is working on an important project with an external deadline which must be met, then:

- The project is flagged during annual or bi-annual planning
- Resources are allocated and typically the team gets generous headcount to either hire or transfer people in
- Regular milestones are set whose progress is tracked

What happens when unexpected delays occur? For an organization in peacetime, this isn't a big deal and there's several options:

1. The scope of the work can be cut for this launch. Given there's no real competitive pressure, launching with a more limited feature set might be acceptable. Post-deadline, the team will ship the remaining features.
2. The team can ask for more staffing from other teams, in order to catch up. Given most teams are not under pressure, a team working on lower priority work can usually lend a few engineers.

There’s also the option for team members to put in more work by doing overtime to meet the deadline. However, in a true “peacetime organization”, it rarely comes to this. Common responses are to reduce scope and “borrow” colleagues from other teams.

A *little* crunchtime at the tail end of a project is typical during the final week, or for one or two days to polish things up. However, extended crunch periods are common at wartime orgs, when the scope cannot be cut on the basis it might cost customers or market share, or when no other teams can help as they’re already stretched.

When I worked at Microsoft within the Skype organization, we built Skype for Xbox One, to an immovable launch date. My team received more than generous funding; hiring about 20 engineers and SDETs (Software Developer Engineer in Test,) and we built the product in about 12 months.

During the final 3 months of the project we ran into trouble because the Xbox One platform kept changing, and apps were allocated fewer hardware resources than expected. Suddenly, we were behind schedule. We responded like this:

1. Reduce the scope of what we would ship on day 1. We originally planned to ship group video calling, with several video streams displaying on-screen in-game. However, we didn’t have the time to re-build this with a much lower CPU allocation, so we cut it for launch.
2. Pull in more people. The Xbox One platform started to change rapidly and our app was broken on a daily basis. Our leadership team made the case for more staffing and we brought in a dedicated SDET to help automate testing.
3. Pull slightly longer hours in the final weeks. Near the end of the project, one of our engineers flew out to Redmond, Washington, to sit next to the Xbox One team, while the rest of us were in London. This engineer worked long hours to make sure we were ready for launch, as did we all.

Reflecting on this, Microsoft and our Skype team operated in peacetime mode; we could cut scope and pull in more staffing. And yes, there was a short crunchtime near the finish. However, at Microsoft it was short and the exception, while at Uber it was the norm and lasted for extended periods of time.

5. Transitioning between wartime and peacetime

Why do companies change between these two ways of working, and what signs that it's happening at your workplace?

From peacetime to wartime

A timely focus of this article is the transition to wartime, which is what's happening at a large number of tech companies.

The most common reasons for this transition:

- **Competition.** A competitor threatens to overtake your company in market share, brand awareness, public profile, or perception-wise. For example, when Google launched Google+ in 2011, the threat of it winning in social media pushed Facebook into "wartime" mode.
- **Decreasing market share.** Numbers don't lie; if your company's market share nosedives, it's likely wartime.
- **Financial health.** If your company is producing poor financial results, like steep drops in profits or revenue, this could trigger a shift out of peacetime mode.
- **Running out of money.** A potential outcome of financial troubles is running out of money. Sadly, this is timely for venture-funded startups reliant on fundraising for income. Growing the business and defying the economic climate, or making heavy cuts, are two options for survival without new funding.
- **Stock price and shareholder pressure.** For publicly traded companies, when the stock price goes down, shareholders are unhappy. Executives' compensation tends to be tied to stock, so they're also unhappy. Wartime tactics are common in this situation, as are job cuts. As a recent TechCrunch article put it: "The layoffs continue until (investor) morale improves."
- **Investor pressure.** For privately traded companies, there's no stock price to watch. However, if investors are uncertain about expected returns, they can put pressure on a company to move into wartime mode.

It's easy to spot signs of a transition to wartime:

- **The CEO rallies the troops.** While peacetime is rarely announced, wartime is almost always communicated, via email, during an all-hands, or usually both. The CEO explains the grave nature of a threat the company faces, and how the coming time will be stressful but necessary for the company to succeed.
- **A change at the top.** The CEO or another executive being replaced explicitly for failing to achieve the desired business results. A new executive makes it clear on day one that they will operate more as a wartime leader. Only yesterday (27 March,) Lyft appointed a new CEO to replace the cofounder, which could well signal a transition to wartime at the company.
- **Ruthless prioritization, from the top.** During wartime, a few top priorities are made clear. These priorities are frequently related to revenue, profit, market share or category position. Anything that doesn't support these is not a priority, and might be cut for financial reasons or due to shareholder pressure.
- **Stricter performance reviews and PIPs.** During wartime, performance reviews are always stricter and employees not seen as meeting the bar are exited, usually after a performance improvement plan (PIP) process. During peacetime, such exits are far rarer.
- **Speed above all.** Shipping quickly and being first-to-market is a focus and there's a tangible sense of urgency.
- **A more "raw" leadership communication style.** Emails and all-hands are less polished than before. The CEO may display impatience or frustration, especially when employees raise "peacetime topics" like perks or work-life-balance.

Layoffs *usually* signal it's wartime – but not always. While layoffs are common during wartime, it's a generalization to say they always mean war. This is especially the case right now, when hundreds of tech companies are executing deep job cuts. If a company does layoffs but none of the other things mentioned above, then it's possible the business intends to operate as in peacetime and that the layoffs are a one-off, with no intent to change the culture.

From wartime to peacetime

Below are common reasons why this transition tends to happen:

- **Negative perception.** A company's reputation is in a downward spiral, so leadership takes drastic action, basically by being more "nice" and less demanding.
- **Too much negative media coverage**. Bad Press often comes from employees leaking sensitive details into the public domain, due to feeling dissatisfied with their working environment.
- **Preparing for an IPO or sale.** When preparing a business to go public, or to be sold, leadership might decide it's safer to steady the ship and avoid missteps that come from moving fast. When preparing to go public, it can also be important to change the culture from a rogue-like working style, to a more regulated, process-led approach.
- **A competitive market for hiring and retaining.** If a company finds it's struggling to hire staff and that new joiners leave quickly, then an underlying reason may be an over-pressurized workplace. If the business no longer needs to be in wartime mode but still is, and attrition is high, then the sensible decision could be to gradually change the culture.

As an employee, what are signs that a transition is underway from wartime to peacetime? Here's some:

- **Major leadership changes.** A new CEO or new C-level hires who emphasize process, and lack the visible urgency that was formerly present.
- **Less strict focus on business goals and competition.** Wartime companies tend to obsess about a very small number of very key business goals, and progress made against competitors. If this focus starts to fade, then the company could be shifting to peacetime.
- **New employee-friendly policies.** Most "peacetime companies" take good care of staff. A sign of a move to peacetime might be leadership focusing on work-life-balance and employee wellbeing. These could mean introducing more generous parental leave policies, wellness budgets, improved pension plans, and more.
- **A focus on employer brand.** "Peacetime companies" are much more focused on their employer brand, as they can afford to think longer-term and are untroubled

by staff working on projects without immediate benefits, which may – or may not – pay dividends in the long term. Sponsoring various groups, diversity and inclusion initiatives, funding of networking and brand building events, investing in attendance at conferences and industry events, may all signal a shift to peacetime.

As a manager, there's other signs you'll likely observe during performance calibrations and promotions:

- **More focus on "how" than "what."** While there's still plenty of focus on the impact which people ship (the "what,") there's a growing expectation for results to be achieved in a textbook way (the "how.") For example, an engineer may ship a complex project which in peacetime may be downgraded if they didn't create an RFC, first. But in wartime, this omission doesn't warrant a mention and the engineer would likely be praised for moving faster.
- **Conflict penalized.** High performers who are perceived as frequently creating conflicts could get penalized for this behavior in reviews, regardless of results.
- **More focus on mentoring and helping others.** Activities like mentoring, participation in recruitment events and other non-"core" activities can help people move into higher buckets, as well as the impact of their work.

One thing you certainly won't see is the leadership making clear that it's now peacetime. This is because no company *wants* to be vocal about entering peacetime mode because it doesn't want competitors – or investors! – to think it's "slacking off" compared to other companies.

Entering peacetime is about going from continuous repeated sprints, to a more sustainable pace. It's much slower than sprinting is, but over time the company gets ahead of "stop-and-go" sprinters.

Transitioning to peacetime after a long wartime period can be difficult for some people. You might assume everyone will be thrilled to shift from high-stress wartime, to lower-stress, more predictable peacetime. But this isn't the case, as I've seen first-hand. Plenty of people leave jobs because they miss being in a high-pressure wartime environment.

The biggest changes when entering peacetime:

1. Shipping quickly is no longer a priority compared to following processes
2. More processes are introduced that need to be followed during shipping
3. The pace is more sustainable and feels much slower
4. Decisions engineers used to make autonomously, now need alignment
5. Internal politics becomes more important. For some, it seems that having a good network matters more than doing quality work, fast. We cover why understanding and getting good at politics is important for software engineers, especially during peacetime

Based on this list, which engineers are likely to be disappointed by peacetime? It's easy to guess: hard-working developers who like to move fast, make decisions on the spot, and ignore processes that make no sense to them. These are also people who tend to seek exciting opportunities elsewhere by quitting for smaller companies, startups, or even larger companies in wartime mode.

It's not just engineers who can struggle with the change. As a manager at Uber, I struggled, too. I'd got used to the "wartime way" of moving fast and encouraging engineers to make decisions. When you do, mistakes happen more often. As the company transitioned to peacetime, I had to realize that causing an outage was no longer an acceptable cost of moving fast, and nor was it okay to skip things like RFCs.

Luckily, I noticed signs of the shift from wartime and started to verbalize the new and changed expectations upon the team. I say "luckily," because during a promotion cycle I observed promotions being rejected that would have passed a "wartime promotion committee". These were engineers who'd delivered impressive results but skipped processes like code reviews and design documents. It was now peacetime, and the "how" mattered just as much as the "what."

6. Thriving in wartime vs thriving in peacetime

As an employee, how can you thrive during both wartime or peacetime? Below are a few approaches:

Area	"Wartime" leadership	"Peacetime" leadership
Getting things done	Do it quickly, with good enough quality. "Done is better than perfect."	Get things done, and do it well, with high quality. "Slow and stable is better than fast and wobbly."
Conflict	Be unafraid of conflicts when they help you move faster. Don't take conflicts personally: it's often not about you, but the stress of "wartime."	Avoid conflicts, even if they'd help you move faster. Figure out why your conflicts happen, as they're unwelcome during "peacetime."
Allies	If you need to work with another team to get things done, do so. Don't worry about allies.	Make allies across the teams you work with; they will help you get things done, and possibly aid your career.
Internal politics	If you have good standing with the CEO/CTO, then you're good. Everything else is usually a bonus.	Important for career advancement, especially in senior positions. Manage upwards, sideways, and down as well.
Priorities	Work only on things the business needs, right now.	Also work on longer-term initiatives which can help the business.
Job stability	Work like your job depends on it, because it might.	Job security, with time and space to do things well.
Pacing yourself	Know that always sprinting can end badly. Pace yourself.	Know that slow and steady can become too slow. Switch up gears sometimes.
A common risk to avoid	Avoid burnout, it's a big risk.	Avoid stagnating or becoming bored, both are risks.

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Thriving in wartime and peacetime. View this table as a document

7. Tech debt at companies with extended wartime periods

An underrated topic that impacts all of us engineers is tech debt. This refers to old engineering decisions which slow down development or maintenance, today. These could be as minor as leftover cleanup tasks, all the way to delayed architecture, framework, or language changes, which cause pain when working with systems.

At companies operating in peacetime, there's plenty of opportunity to address these problems. Most peacetime tech companies tend to allocate a healthy part of engineering work to paying off tech and architecture debt, usually 10-30% of the engineering team's time. Also, engineers are rarely overworked during "peacetime," so can address tech debt by putting in a few more hours, without impacting their existing work.

Tech debt can – and does! – accumulate at companies in wartime mode. Getting things done quickly is more important than finding the best solution, including for maintenance. This means tech debt snowballs and there's usually very little capacity to pay it off.

So, amid continuous firefighting, the quantity of debt grows larger and larger. Over time, it *should* become unbearable and force the company to grind to halt, unable to develop new features quickly. Right? Actually, this usually doesn't happen. From personal experience and talking with engineers at startups who've only known a wartime mode, tech debt is not a top concern.

So why do many companies in lengthy wartime phases not suffer badly with "tech debt"? Uber was a case where a "wartime" focus might have been expected to seriously impede it from moving fast. And yet, move fast the company did. Here are some counterintuitive reasons why a wartime setting needn't be bad for tech debt:

1. Constraints foster creativity in cutting tech debt. It's true that during crunchtime, there's pressure to ship and tech debt is accepted with the intent of paying it off later. During long periods of wartime, engineers know they need to maintain what they build and that there isn't dedicated time for paying off tech debt.

Turns out, capable engineers then make pragmatic – often elegant – decisions which reduce future tech debt. When Uber rewrote its Rider app, most teams only had 3 months to migrate to a brand new architecture called RIBs, which the Mobile Platform team had built 3 months earlier. The Mobile Platform team was short on time, but decided to put a framework in place to reduce the maintenance load for the new Uber app, in the short-term. Uber's Mobile Platform team was full of experienced and capable engineers and the time constraint pushed them to be creative. Who can say if RIBs would have been built without such constraints.

2. Improving maintainability becomes table stakes to not burn out, as an engineer. During peacetime, it's not really a problem if a system is hard to extend or maintain: you just estimate longer and take more time. After all, you have it.

But during wartime, the pain multiples. As an engineer it's stressful to work with an architecture that's hard to extend, unreliable systems, or to keep running into issues as more customers use the system. And time's not on your side, as in "peacetime."

During an extended wartime, it becomes essential to be able to explain to other engineers *what* the real problem with systems is, and what a fix would look like. Why is this essential? By verbalizing the problem and solution, you can get their support to act on it, quickly. And you might get an opportunity because:

3. Rewriting systems is easier to justify during wartime than in peacetime. During peacetime, large decisions need alignment with many stakeholders. For example, rewriting a payments system involves months of persuading all stakeholders, many of whom probably want to avoid risks.

But during wartime, decisions like this can be made at the discretion of a team, or an engineer, if progress is fast. Engineering teams at wartime startups frequently build new systems when their existing ones accumulate too much debt, or become less reliable.

While rewriting systems might seem wasteful, there's very good reasons for it, including:

- Usage of the old system has increased by a large magnitude. This also implies the business is growing rapidly, so a new approach might be needed.
- The use cases the system needs to support are very different from what the original system was designed for. So a new system is built, instead of painfully retro-fitting the old one.
- The rewrite is quick; a few weeks or less.

Even if a rewrite decision is wrong, during a wartime period there's fewer levers that opponents of the decision can pull to stop it.

4. Greenfield projects are more common. One thing that's much easier to justify than a rewrite is building a new system. During a prolonged period of wartime, moving fast is vital. If an existing system would take too long to extend, putting a new one in place is usually the preferred decision. The bias towards greenfield projects comes with an interesting architectural pull:

5. Microservices can be a more natural fit in a wartime environment. There’s already a pull to build new services, so why not make it easy? This is the reasoning process many experienced engineers go through, so it makes sense to allow teams to build new services quickly, and then operate those services.

These days, both the know-how and the tooling make it easier to build and operate smaller services. Also, above a certain level of complexity, a large monolith needs to be either modularized, or split into smaller services.

This doesn’t mean companies using microservices are in wartime. However, I’ve observed microservices making it easier to operate in this setup: teams can keep moving fast, take on only the tech debt they want to, and not have to extend services owned by another team. However, going from a monolith to microservices can be a considerable challenge. In a previous issue, we cover how it took Khan Academy 3.5 years to break up its monolith, though the company wasn’t in wartime mode.

Takeaways

Given current events in Ukraine and elsewhere, “wartime” is an unhappy metaphor. There’s no intent to trivialize or minimize the suffering war causes, by applying some of its features to a competitive environment in which people are fighting to save their jobs. Sadly, war is a human activity whose lessons apply to other, less destructive, of our endeavors. For example, ‘The Art of War’ by Sun Tzu, is an ancient military manual still quoted in articles about succeeding in business or in life, and there are many books for entrepreneurs which frame starting a company as like going to war.

The “wartime” and “peacetime” phases of a company are highly distinctive. While wartime is more stressful as an employee, for the company it’s also when staff operate with higher efficiency and focus. Peacetime, on the other hand, is a much better working environment for staff, but the pace might be slower, even though there’s enough time to invest in longer-term projects that would get no focus during wartime.

Most companies alternate between wartime and peacetime phases. For a successful venture-funded startup that eventually IPO's, it typically looks like this:

1. Founding: wartime. The founders work long hours to build a prototype and hope it clicks with early customers.
2. Fundraising: wartime. The team works around the clock to prove to investors there's something worth investing in.
3. After fundraising: brief peacetime. With funding secured, the team has breathing space to focus on the longer-term: grow the team, build the core idea, and do a few experiments on the side. The earlier the startup stage, the shorter this period.
4. Between fundraising rounds: the same oscillation. As pressure mounts; for example, if funding starts running out or competitors come out of nowhere, then the company returns to wartime more.
5. A year before a planned IPO: wartime. In a final push to get the business metrics where they should be, the company focuses its priorities on areas it thinks investors care about.
6. After the IPO: it depends. With a very successful IPO, where the share price keeps going up, it's hard for the culture not to change to peacetime. Things are going well, after all! However, if the IPO does not go well and the business struggles, then it's more likely wartime tactics will be used.
7. As a public company: more of a pull to operate as in peacetime. Companies that do well on the market for consecutive quarters or years, tend to transition to peacetime. A lot depends on leadership, of course.

Companies don't alternate between war and peace modes because they necessarily want to: they do it because they have to. Many leaders would likely prefer to always operate in a high output mode akin to wartime, but there are several problems with this:

- Attrition is much higher
- Some great people leave because of burnout, who would stay if they were less stressed

- It's hard to execute a long-term strategy because there's no incentive to aim long-term
- It's hard to motivate people to keep operating in wartime mode when the business is clearly thriving

The result of a successful wartime focus is that the company gets ahead in the market and creates enough space to recoup. This cycle then repeats itself.

The sooner you figure out how to be efficient in both modes, the better off you'll be. Whatever company you work at, you'll surely notice a shift when it happens. Right now, more companies are transitioning into a wartime mode, compared to 2021 when many scaleups raised historic funding rounds and transitioned from wartime to peacetime.

Figure out where your team and organization is right now, employ strategies to do well in that setting, and assume that sooner or later, things are going to change again, and that you'll need to adapt once more.

What other observations do you have about the peacetime and wartime states? Share in a comment below.

For a browsable version of the tables comparing "wartime" and "peacetime", [see this Google Doc](https://docs.google.com).

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11 Comments

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Siddharth Goel Mar 31

Insightful piece 👍 The section I found most interesting was the reasons why even an extended wartime doesn't into a very bad tech debt 💯

LIKE (2) REPLY ...

Joseph Mar 29

Is there a name for a company that attempts both wartime and peacetime management at the same time? Maybe the company is at war with itself?

LIKE (2) REPLY ...

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